



Learning Space

IAS MAINS 2020

ETHICS, INTEGRITY & APTITUDE

CASE STUDIES

MODULE - 1

CASE STUDY - 1

A large metropolitan city that is the economic engine of the country has colonial-era over-crowded suburban train system and huge infrastructure deficit. The Government proposed to build major metro rail lines to ease the traffic, reduce the pollution and boost the economy. However, the cost for land acquisition, to build both the lines and metro car-sheds, for the project is abnormally high. There is a vacant thickly wooded forest of around 50 hectares, which is suitable for metro car-shed. The cost of acquisition of land of the same area from private parties costs Rs. 20,000 Cr. The Government, after weighing the cost benefit analysis, has decided to locate the metro car-shed in this forested area, requiring felling of around 5,000 trees. The public perception, however, is staunchly against cutting of the trees. Several protests were held by the citizen groups against the government's decision and some of them have even turned violent.

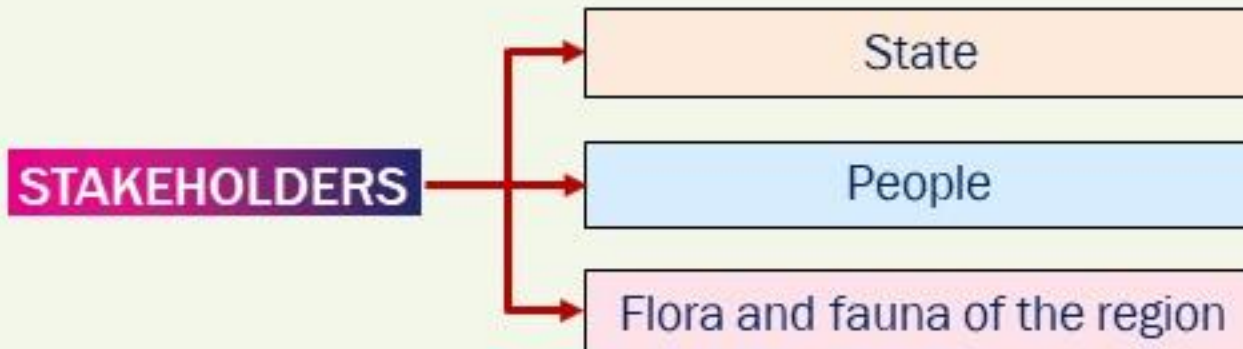
As the Municipal Commissioner of the city, identify the options available to you in dealing with the situation. What course of action would you recommend?

CASE STUDIES

This case is a classical example of emerging debates on environment inclusive development as an alternate to environment vs. development.

ETHICAL ISSUES INVOLVED

- Urban crisis of traffic, pollution and need for economic growth.
- Protecting environment, forests in the context of uncertain, frequent disasters (Eg: Western Ghats mining and Kerala floods and landslides).
- State is a trustee of the people's resources (Gandhi) vs. State as owner of natural resources.
- Deforestation vs. Compensatory afforestation.



CASE STUDIES

As the municipal commissioner of the metropolitan city, I found the following options.

OPTION 1

Go ahead with construction of metro shed by imposing section 144 in protest region, if required

MERITS

- Ease of traffic and pollution in city.
- Metro as engine of growth.
- Barriers from the protests prevented.
- Finances saved for the State.

DEMERITS

- State loses people's trust in democracy.
- Disables participatory governance.
- May lead to adverse long term consequences impacted by the disasters like flooding the deforested and downstream regions etc.
- Flora and fauna of the region may become extinct.

OPTION 2

Avoid metro shed in the region and choose other places where issues of protests don't exist

MERITS

- Follows the people's choice and thus reinforces trust on state and democracy.
- No barriers to construct metro shed at other place.
- Forest, flora and fauna are protected.

DEMERITS

- Other development programmes may also be obstructed in the name of environment.
- Increased financial burden on state.
- Metro shed at another place may not be viable.
- Urban crisis not solved.

CASE STUDIES

OPTION 3

- Start an inclusive dialogue with representatives of protesters.
- Make them aware about the urban crisis showing facts and need of metro shed.
- Assure them that all their grievances and ideals will be included in the project and redesign it as environment friendly as possible.
- Appoint popularly respected officers like Metro man Sreedharan as project director to increase people's trust.
- Implement the project with the support of people.
- Take cautionary measures with full environment impact assessment.

RECOMMENDED COURSE OF ACTION

OPTION 3

REASONS

- Gandhi's principle of state as a trustee and the reality that state is owner, are realized.
- With minimum felling of trees, it will be not only be forest friendly but also can be a tourist attraction.
- Minimum harm to flora and fauna is done.
- With people's support and trust, it ensures participatory governance and prompt project completion.
- Urban crisis is solved.
- State finances are optimally utilised.

LONG TERM MEASURES

- Open a dedicated website to update the environmental and administration situation of the region.
- Timely periodic monitoring and assessment of the region in the context of any emerging disasters in future.

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